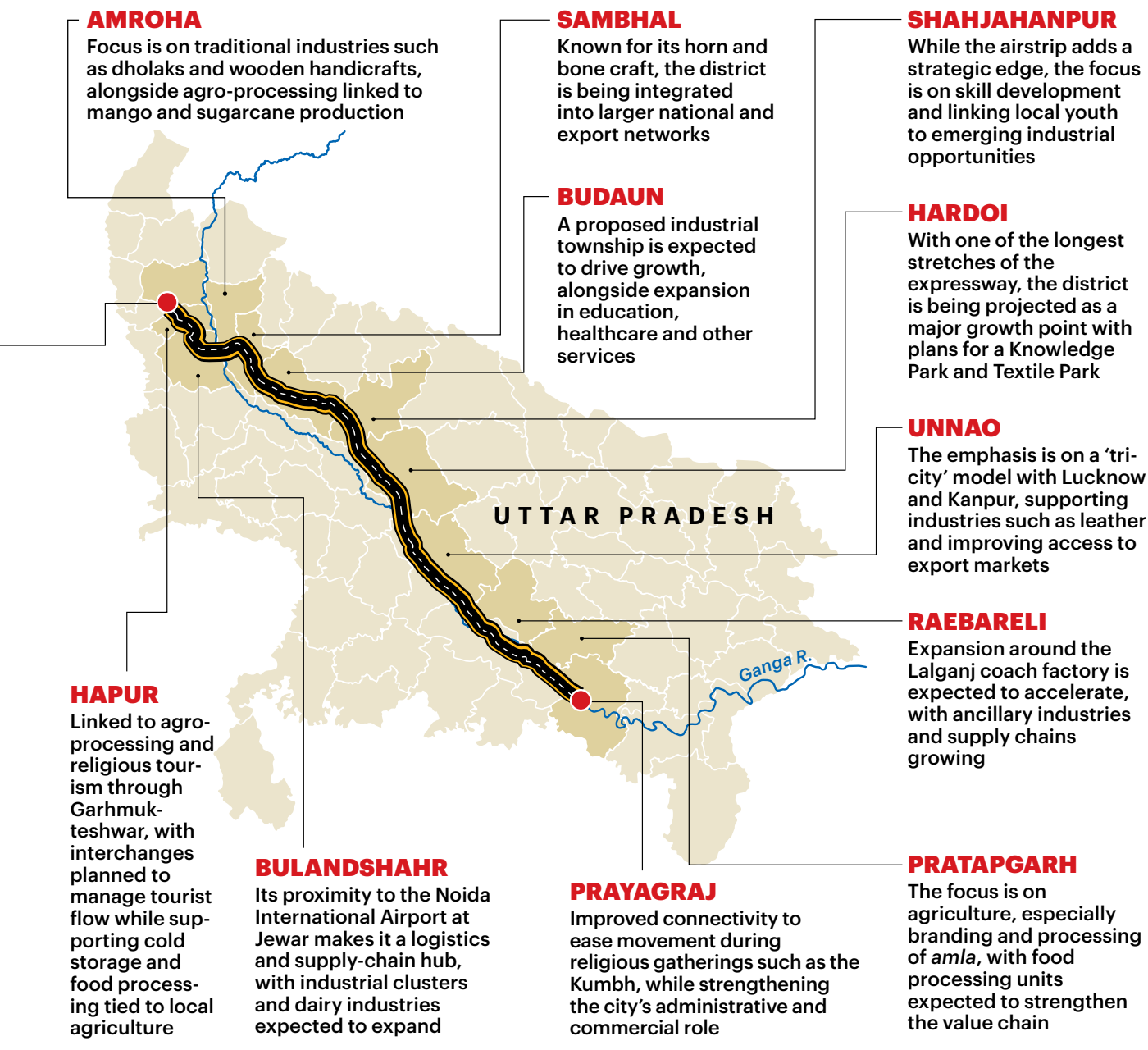


Group, instead of being assigned to a single contractor. Officials say this multi-package approach allowed construction to begin simultaneously across different stretches. "There is no favouritism in Uttar Pradesh. The process involves open bidding, and everything is done transparently," Kumar says. "You can see this in other projects as well. Take Jewar airport, for example, where Zurich Airport International AG, a foreign company, won the bid."

The idea for the Ganga Expressway emerged as part of the Yogi government's broader push to connect different regions of the state through high-speed corridors.

Over the past few years, UP has invested heavily in expressways—from Purvanchal and Bundelkhand to the Ganga corridor now—betting that improved connectivity will drive economic activity across the state. "After the Purvanchal and Bundelkhand Expressways were started, the chief minister [after taking office in 2017] felt there should be an expressway linking Haridwar and Prayagraj," says Awanish Awasthi, currently the CM's chief adviser and formerly the CEO of UPEIDA during the project's execution phase. "More than Rs 7,000 crore was arranged through the budget for acquiring land. Eventually, this became the largest PPP model project in the roads sector in the country." The foundation stone for the Ganga Expressway project was laid by PM Modi in Shahjahanpur on December 18, 2021.

Now, as the Ganga Expressway enters everyday use, its success is likely to be judged not just by the speed and scale of its construction, but by whether it delivers jobs, investment and broader economic activity along its stretch. ■